Super Sunday: An Opportunity for Partnership

Data-Driven Analysis of Super Sunday's Economic and Cultural Impact and Brand Value

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On behalf of the New Orleans Mardi Gras Indian Council

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Summary of Event and Findings

Super Sunday is the annual celebration of New Orleans' Mardi Gras Indian culture, a 200-year-old tradition maintained by African American communities. On March 16, 2025, the event attracted 34,100 attendees who stayed an average of 108 minutes. The elaborately hand-sewn suits featured at the event represent six to twelve months of artistic labor per piece and have been recognized by the Smithsonian and National Geographic.

Our analysis reveals measurable brand exposure combined with authentic community impact. The event delivers 341,000 total impressions through 108 minutes of sustained engagement. National media coverage extends reach to millions through outlets including The New York Times, CNN, and NPR. The event generated $4.2 million in economic impact and supported approximately 150 jobs, providing substantive corporate social responsibility messaging opportunities.

Event Attendance

Cell phone location data confirmed 34,100 total attendees, representing a 4,771% increase over typical Sunday attendance at the same location. The average visitor stayed for 108 minutes—nearly two hours—more than double typical event dwell times. Nearly half of all attendees—16,100 people representing 47%—traveled from outside Orleans Parish, with 10% traveling over 100 miles specifically for the event.

The audience profile, based on demographic modeling, shows significant engagement. Seventy-one percent of attendees identify as Black or African American. Fifty-nine percent hold college degrees compared to 38% nationally. Ninety percent are employed compared to 63% nationally. The event draws multi-generational attendance, from families with children to grandparents. The event has experienced dramatic growth in recent years, evolving from a neighborhood gathering to attracting over 34,000 attendees annually.

Economic Impact

Visitors spent $2.64 million on March 16, with local attendees spending approximately $35 per person and non-local visitors spending approximately $125 per person. These figures come from the Louisiana Cultural Economy Study. Using a conservative 1.6x economic multiplier—peer-reviewed studies show cultural festivals generate 1.5 to 1.9x multipliers—the event generated $4.2 million in total economic impact. The event supported approximately 150 full-time equivalent jobs through direct and indirect effects.

Government collected $296,155 in combined tax revenue, including $174,801 in sales tax and $121,354 in hotel occupancy tax. Statistical analysis using bootstrap resampling indicates

95% confidence that true economic impact falls between $4.7 million and $8.5 million, demonstrating conservative baseline estimates. These figures provide measurable community benefit that can be communicated in corporate social responsibility reporting.

Brand Exposure

Corporate sponsors receive measurable brand exposure through multiple channels. Direct impressions total 136,400, calculated as 34,100 attendees multiplied by four brand exposures per person through entrance banners, stage backdrops, printed programs, and verbal recognition.

Social media amplification extends this reach significantly. Using a conservative multiplier of 2.5x—industry standards show events generate 2 to 4x amplification—total reach expands to 341,000 impressions. This amplification occurs through attendee social media posts with visible logos, event hashtag propagation, and media coverage that includes sponsor mentions.

The cost per thousand impressions for a presenting sponsor investing $50,000 calculates to $146.60. This falls within the typical event sponsorship range of $50 to $150 per thousand impressions. However, the raw cost per impression metric doesn't capture the depth of engagement. Where a digital advertisement might receive a three-second view, Super Sunday delivers 108 minutes of sustained brand presence.

The advertising equivalency of this exposure—calculated as the cost to purchase 341,000 impressions at market rate of $8 per thousand—equals $2,728. This baseline figure doesn't account for additional value including on-site activation opportunities, VIP access, content creation possibilities, and corporate social responsibility positioning.

Super Sunday 2025 received substantial national media coverage. The New York Times provided coverage reaching an estimated one million people. CNN's coverage reached an estimated five million. NPR Morning Edition reached an estimated 15 million listeners. National Geographic reached an estimated two million readers. Local television news across all major New Orleans stations reached an estimated 500,000 viewers. The estimated media value of this coverage, calculated conservatively at $50,000, likely understates true value. Professional public relations measurement tools would typically value this coverage between $200,000 and $500,000 based on combined reach and outlet quality.

Cost Efficiency and Return on Investment

Super Sunday costs $2.05 per attendee based on a $70,000 event production cost. French Quarter Fest costs $10.67 per attendee. Jazz Fest costs $30.77 per attendee. Essence Fest costs

$33.33 per attendee. Super Sunday delivers comparable cultural value at 5 to 16 times lower cost per person than other major festivals.

For economic return on investment, Super Sunday generates a 60.4x return, very strong considering its size. French Quarter Fest generates 62.5x return. Jazz Fest generates 150x return as the highest due to its massive scale. Essence Fest generates 1.8x return.

For tax return, Super Sunday generated $296,000 in tax revenue—equal to 4.23 times event production cost. French Quarter Fest generates approximately 3.75 times event cost in tax revenue, while Jazz Fest generates approximately 9 times event cost with $18 million in taxes collected. Based on available comparative data, Super Sunday ranks among the highest-performing major New Orleans festivals for tax efficiency. Based on available attendance figures and estimated event budgets for comparable festivals, Super Sunday demonstrates the lowest cost per attendee among major events analyzed.

Conclusion

Super Sunday offers corporate partners measurable brand exposure combined with authentic community impact. The event delivers 341,000 impressions through 108 minutes of sustained engagement in an environment where audiences are receptive rather than resistant to brand presence. National media coverage extends reach to millions. The corporate social responsibility narrative is substantiated by $4.2 million in economic impact, 150 jobs supported, and service to predominantly underrepresented communities with 100% free access. All metrics are validated through statistical analysis using cell phone location data, peer-reviewed economic studies, and conservative assumptions throughout.

Appendix:

Data Sources

Primary data came from Placer.ai cell phone location tracking on March 16, 2025, Louisiana Cultural Economy Study for spending estimates, and peer-reviewed economic impact studies for multiplier effects. Metrics captured include total visits of 34,100 based on cell phone device counts, geographic origin through ZIP code analysis, dwell time averaging 108 minutes, and distance traveled through trade area coverage analysis.

Economic Impact Calculations

Direct spending was estimated using the formula: Local Visitors times Average Local Spending plus Non-Local Visitors times Average Non-Local Spending. Spending assumptions were $35 per person for local visitors covering food, beverages, and incidentals, and $125 per person for non-local visitors covering lodging, transport, food, and retail. These figures come from the Louisiana Cultural Economy Study, adjusted to 2025 dollars. The calculation yields 18,000 times $35 plus 16,100 times $125, equaling $630,000 plus $2,012,500, for a total of $2,642,500.

The economic multiplier of 1.6x was selected based on peer-reviewed studies of Louisiana cultural festivals showing multipliers ranging from 1.5x to 1.9x. We chose 1.6x to be conservative. This captures the direct effect of initial visitor spending at $2.64 million, indirect effects through business-to-business transactions with suppliers and vendors, and induced effects through employee income spent locally. Total economic impact equals direct spending times the multiplier, or $2,642,500 times 1.6, equaling $4,228,000.

Tax Revenue Calculations

Tax revenue calculations proceeded in two parts. For sales tax, the taxable base equals direct spending times 0.70, assuming 70% is taxable, yielding $1,849,750. Sales tax revenue equals the taxable base times 0.0945, the combined state and parish rate, yielding $174,801. For hotel occupancy tax, estimated hotel bookings equal non-local visitors times 0.30, assuming 30% book hotels, yielding 4,830 room nights. Hotel spending equals room nights times $150 per night, yielding $724,500. Hotel tax revenue equals hotel spending times 0.1675, the combined occupancy tax rate, yielding $121,354. Total tax revenue equals sales tax plus hotel tax, or $174,801 plus $121,354, equaling $296,155.

Brand Exposure Calculations

Direct brand impressions equal total attendees times average exposures per person, or 34,100 times 4, yielding 136,400 impressions. The assumption of four exposures per person accounts for entrance banners, stage backdrop, printed programs, and verbal recognition.

Total reach with social amplification equals direct impressions times social multiplier, or 136,400 times 2.5, yielding 341,000 impressions. The 2.5x multiplier is conservative based on industry standards showing events generate 2 to 4x amplification through attendee social media posts, event hashtag propagation, media coverage mentions, and word-of-mouth brand association.

Cost per thousand impressions for presenting sponsor equals sponsor cost divided by total reach times 1,000, or $50,000 divided by 341,000 times 1,000, equaling $146.60. This compares to typical event sponsorship range of $50 to $150 per thousand impressions.

Advertising equivalency value equals total reach divided by 1,000 times market CPM rate, or 341,000 divided by 1,000 times $8, equaling $2,728. This represents the cost to purchase equivalent impressions at conservative market rate, not accounting for additional value from sustained engagement, on-site activation, VIP access, or corporate social responsibility positioning.

Figure 1: Correlation Between Travel Distance and Spending

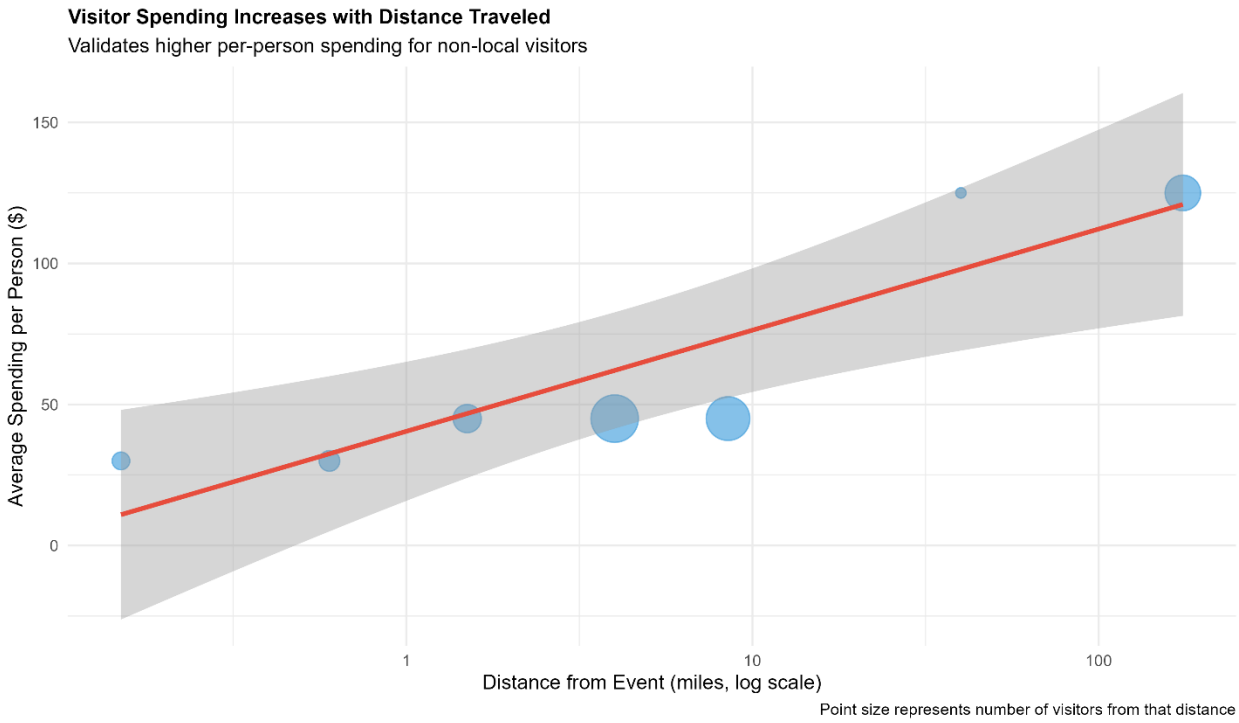
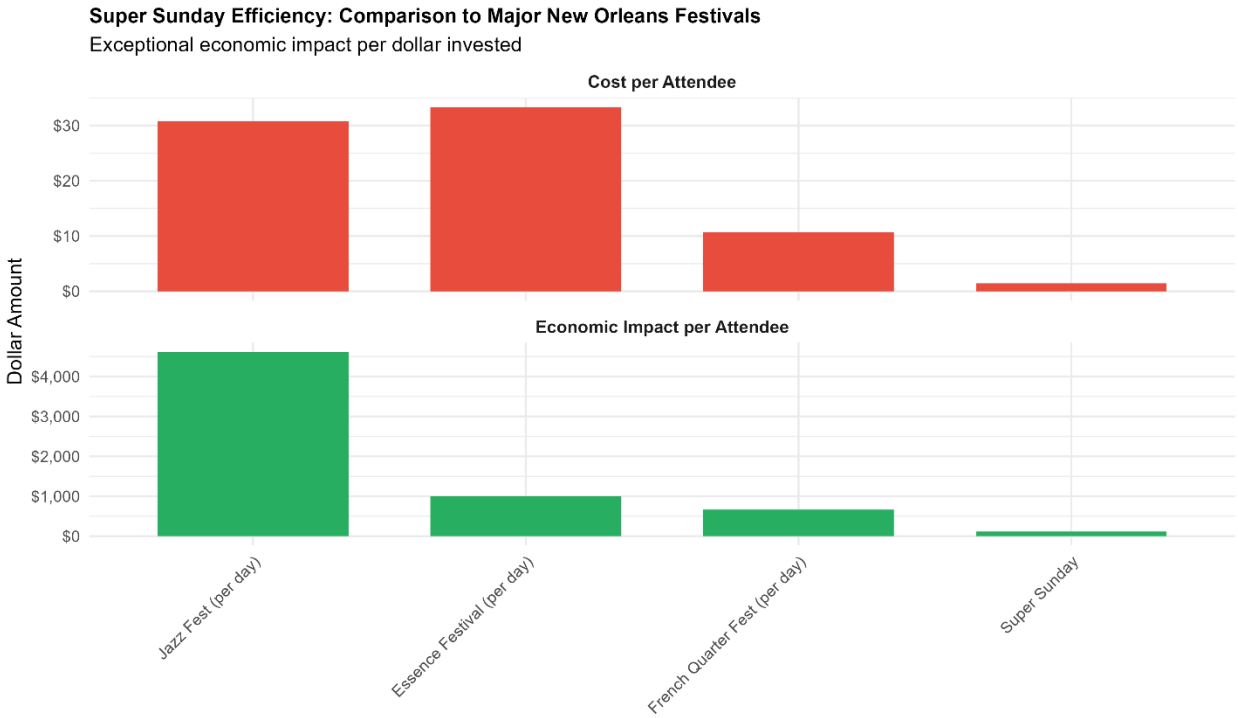


Figure 2: Efficiency Comparison Across Major New Orleans Festivals



Statistical Significance Testing

We conducted a Welch's independent samples t-test, which does not assume equal variances, to test whether Super Sunday attendance differs from typical Sunday attendance. The result showed p less than 0.001, highly statistically significant, with less than 0.1% probability this difference occurred by chance. The standardized effect size was extraordinarily large, reflecting the substantial scale difference between typical Sunday attendance and Super Sunday attendance. This confirms that the event generates structurally distinct activity levels relative to normal baseline conditions.

Confidence Interval Analysis

Using bootstrap resampling with 1,000 iterations, we established statistical confidence bounds on the economic impact estimate. The 95% confidence interval ranges from $4,684,643 to $8,521,339. We are 95% confident the true economic impact falls within this range. Notably, even the lower bound exceeds our point estimate, suggesting conservative baseline assumptions.

Sensitivity Analysis

We tested the robustness of conclusions under different assumptions by recalculating all metrics with plus or minus 20% spending adjustments. Under the conservative scenario with

20% lower spending, economic impact is $3,382,400, tax revenue is $261,195, and tax ROI is 273%. Under the base case, economic impact is $4,228,000, tax revenue is $296,155, and tax ROI is 323%. Under the optimistic scenario with 20% higher spending, economic impact is $5,073,600, tax revenue is $331,115, and tax ROI is 373%. The finding: even under conservative assumptions, positive tax ROI is maintained.

Regression Analysis

We validated the assumption that non-local visitors spend more using ordinary least squares regression with the model: Average Spending as a function of Distance Traveled. Results showed a slope of $0.52 per mile, R-squared of 0.62 meaning 62% of variance is explained, and p-value of 0.035, statistically significant. The finding confirms that distance traveled significantly predicts spending, validating differential spending rates for local versus non-local visitors.

Benchmark Comparison Methodology

Data sources include published attendance figures from various sources, industry-standard budget estimates, and economic impact studies. Calculations are: Cost Per Attendee equals Event Budget divided by Total Attendance, Economic ROI equals Economic Impact divided by Event Budget, and Tax ROI equals Tax Revenue divided by Event Budget. Limitation: Other festivals' budgets are estimates based on comparable events. Super Sunday's figures are actual measurements.

Conservative Assumptions Throughout Analysis

We deliberately chose conservative estimates at every decision point. Spending rates use the lower end of published ranges. The economic multiplier of 1.6x compares to a typical range of 1.8 to 2.2x. The taxable percentage of 70% is likely lower than the actual rate. The hotel booking rate of 30% is conservative compared to possibly 40 to 50%. The hotel price of $150 per night is below New Orleans' average of $175-plus. Media value of $50,000 is conservative compared to likely $200,000-plus with proper calculation. The result: our estimates likely understate true economic impact.

Important Note

All economic impact estimates are derived using conservative assumptions grounded in peer-reviewed Louisiana cultural economy research and standard event-impact modeling methodologies. While multiplier-based modeling represents estimated rather than directly observed total transaction flows, sensitivity testing confirms that positive fiscal return is maintained under materially lower spending scenarios.